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Handwave lends a hand
to retailers with its
European alternative to
Amazon's palm
payments



Paying with a handwave once sounded like science fiction, but [contactless palm recognition service Amazon One](#) has already been used [more than 8 million times](#), according to the company. That's Amazon, though, which explains why it has been deployed in Amazon stores and more than 500 Whole Foods Market stores in the U.S., but only 150 third-party locations.

Meanwhile, fintech startups like Latvia's [Handwave](#) are stepping onto the field, aiming to provide third-party retailers with a similar but independent solution for faster checkout while leveraging the giant's role in popularizing biometric payments in the West. (China has already begun adopting biometric palm payments, with Tencent working to [bring its Weixin Palm Pay service into mainstream use](#).)

Like Apple's Face ID, palm scanning uses more than static images: It analyzes palm vein patterns and also verifies that the user is physically present when they hover their hand over the scanner. This method works for secure contactless payments and also applies to broader identity verification scenarios — with players like Keyo also supporting [secure building access and other applications](#).

In contrast, Handwave is focusing specifically on retail — and since it doesn't own stores like Amazon, it had to seek partners, which required having a product. Three years in, and now with its

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own hardware and software, the Latvian startup is preparing for market pilots that will deploy its palm-scanning devices at retail stores.

Merchants who deploy the startup's tech would pay a transaction fee that Handwave claims will be on par with or lower than standard payments.

According to Handwave, faster and cheaper checkouts could reduce costs. But unlike some cost-cutting measures, this solution aims to make things easier for customers — with the promise of no cards, no apps, no fingerprint scanners, and no facial scans — even for age verification and loyalty programs.

Handwave's co-founders, CEO Janis Stirna and Sandis Osmanis-Usmanis, previously worked for one of the world's largest global payment providers, Worldline. Despite this connection, the team aims to build a wide ecosystem. "Our plan is to collaborate with any financial institution or acquiring bank," Stirna told TechCrunch.

The startup has only partnered with a handful of financial institutions so far, "but very big ones, especially in Europe," Stirna said. This summer, the startup signed an agreement with Visa that could speed up the deployment of Handwave's solution in any country, according to its chief revenue officer, Oskars Laksevis.

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While Handwave has its eyes on the U.S. market as well, Laksevics believes that it can be an advantage to start out in the European Union — “the strictest market in the world” — and demonstrate compliance there before expanding.

Being an independent European player could also help the startup keep an edge if or when Amazon decides to more aggressively offer Amazon One to third parties; or if JP Morgan rolls out [its own palm payment experiment](#) further.

The startup also can rely on other arguments, including pricing. After financial partners told Handwave its devices need to be able to compete on price, the startup developed its own hardware and algorithms making them cheaper than others, Stirna said.

Being based in Riga also enabled Handwave to operate with limited capital. The startup told TechCrunch its R&D process was funded through bootstrapping, a \$780,000 angel investment round, and \$267,000 in non-equity funding. This sum came from an EU-funded [cybersecurity grant](#), as well as support from Latvia’s [LIAA Business Incubator](#) and EU-backed accelerator [Ready2Scale](#).

As it gears up for its first pilots and obtaining regulatory certifications, Handwave has now secured a \$4.2 million seed funding round led by Vilnius-based VC firm Practica Capital, with participation from FirstPick and Outlast Fund, also

from Lithuania; and Inovo.vc, a Polish VC firm that also operates in the Baltics.

The Baltic states have established themselves as a fintech hub, but also have scientific talent that's easier for a startup like Handwave to attract and afford than in Silicon Valley — including AI engineers. “In the Baltics, there are not a lot of companies where you can get that extreme level of technical challenge to resolve,” Stirna said.

As for Laksevics, who previously held a senior marketing role at Baltic bank Luminor Bank, where Stirna had also worked, he told TechCrunch that he was drawn by the vision. “I left a very well-paid corporate job to join this one, and I truly believe that we are building the next big global payment platform,” he said.

Handwave seems ready to put its best hand forward — but only time will tell if the market will grab on and if biometric palm payments will truly take hold.

Topics: [amazon one](#) [Europe](#) [Fintech](#) [Fundraising](#)

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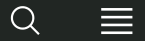
Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

Dominic-Madori Davis — 8:45 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

A new startup, [Lava Payments](#), aims to take on payment giants by building a solution for the modern web where AI agents now handle transactions for their customers. The idea came to

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different wrappers or platforms.” And each time, he had to start a new subscription, re-authenticate, and pay separately, “even though I was already paying for access to the core model.”

“That felt fundamentally broken,” he continued. “I didn’t want to keep rebuying access to the same thing under a different wrapper. What I wanted was a single wallet, one set of credits, and the ability to move between tools and providers without starting over every time so I could pay for what I was using.”

He decided to launch Lava Payments as a solution.

Lava is a digital wallet that lets merchants use usage credits to facilitate transactions.

The idea is that one set of credits working across merchants and services makes it easier for autonomous agents to make payments without needing human intervention. It works like this: A merchant can enable the Lava wallet for their customers to use and upload (credits) money to. Once a customer does that, they can take that money and use it at any merchant that also accepts Lava and any of the foundational models, like GPT and Claude, on a “pay as you go basis,” Jones said.

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So, rather than having to pay for each tool, a user buys a one-time usage credit that AI agents can simply charge as they perform various tasks. No more asking the user to approve transaction after transaction.

“Without Lava, agents can’t move smoothly through the internet because they constantly get blocked when it comes time to pay,” he said. He used Google as an example, saying every time a person opens Google Maps, they don’t have to pay Google for that map, as they’ve already paid Verizon and AT&T to access the internet.

On Wednesday, the startup announced a \$5.8 million seed round led by Lerer Hippeau.

Others in this space include startups like [Metronome](#).

“We see the world as very interconnected,” Jones said about what makes his product different. “What we’re really focused on is building [for the] agent-native economy.”

Born to a working family in Dayton, Ohio, Jones said his parents always told him the best way to get ahead was to work hard, save money, and get a good education.

“You know, a lot of the things that most people are told,” he recalled, when speaking with TechCrunch.

Jones took that advice to heart. He got a good education (Yale), held some good jobs (Goldman, Meta), and then founded some companies (the fintechs Parable and Lendtable, the latter of which was YC S20).

Jones said he met his lead investors for Lava because he went to high school with [Will McKelvey, now an investor at Lerer Hippeau](#). He said McKelvey

has been following his career for a while and always wanted to work together someday, and Lava Payments was that someday.

Others in the round included Harlem Capital, Streamlined Ventures, and Westbound. The fresh capital will be used for hiring, building products, and developing go-to-market strategies.

Overall, Jones is ready for Lava to be the “invisible layer that kind of powers the AI web,” he says, especially as AI agents find themselves more and more in the checkout line.

“We should be enabling agents to move, transact, and build without friction,” he said.

“We want to make sure that AI is something that can be used by every single person, even a kid from Dayton, like myself.”

The title of this piece was updated to properly reflect what the company does.

Topics: [AI](#) [Fintech](#) [Lerer Hippeau](#) [payments](#)

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Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture | [X](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: BREX

FINTECH



IPO hopeful Brex scored major win to sell in the EU, plans UK expansion

Julie Bort — 11:52 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Financial services provider [Brex](#) on Thursday announced that it achieved a major milestone: It is now licensed in the European Union. That means it can now directly issue credit and debit cards and offer its spend management products to any business in all 30 EU countries with “no workarounds required,” as co-founder and CEO Pedro Franceschi wrote [in a blog post](#).

While the corporate spend management startup previously supported 60 currencies in 200 countries, it could only sell its products to companies with a U.S. presence.

With the expansion, Brex is now authorized to sell spend management (complete with issuing cards) and other tools like embedded payments to EU companies and startups, a spokesperson tells TechCrunch. However, there's a caveat: Banking and bill pay will not be initially available. The company hopes to roll those services out in the future.

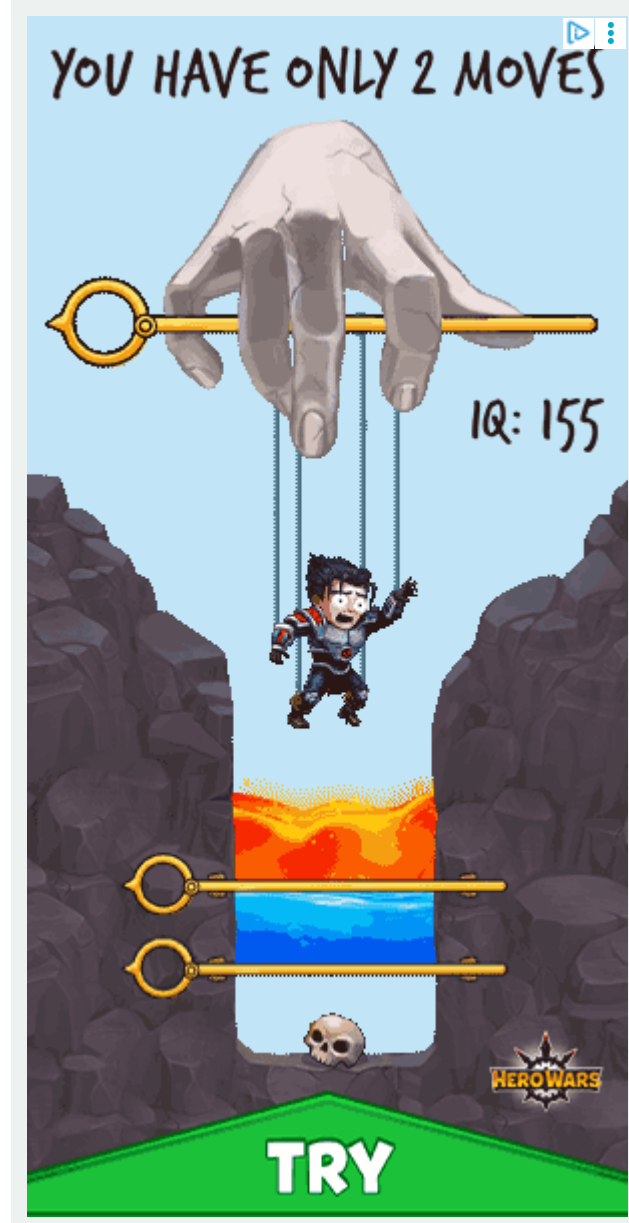
While this is good news for Brex, it may also be good news for European startups. Brex's claim to fame is offering startups expense management cards for their employees even if they wouldn't yet qualify from traditional banks. Without a bank account offering, the youngest EU startups will still have to weigh their options.

Next up, Franceschi says he wants to expand Brex in the U.K., though he offered no specifics on those plans.

Franceschi [said in December](#) that Brex is on track to stop burning cash in 2025, "an important milestone to our future IPO."

In February, sources told various news outlets that Brex was on track for \$500 million in revenue this year as well. That's quite the turnaround from a shaky moment in 2023 when Brex conducted layoffs and reportedly told employees that its cash burn was too high. There has been no hint yet as to when that IPO may take place, though.

Brex's competitive win in the international market comes as its U.S. fintech competitors are having an overall moment. Ramp has been raising money from VCs like mad, [hitting a \\$22.5 billion valuation](#)



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Dominic-Madori Davis
- 1 day ago

[just 45 days](#) after a round with a \$16 billion valuation. In March, [Mercury raised a fresh \\$300 million](#) and doubled its valuation to \$3.5 billion.

Brex has not publicly announced new equity VC funding since 2022, when it raised \$300 million in a [Series D-2 round at a \\$12.3 billion](#) valuation. It did, however, sell a fresh \$260 million of bonds in [March 2024](#), packaged from its spend management receivables which are used to manage that cash-intensive business.

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